

By **Rajesh Nambiar**

SECURING THE GLOBAL **AI ARENA**

AI SECURITY IS THE NEXT BIG FRONTIER IN GLOBAL CYBERSECURITY, AND INDIA **IS WELL PLACED TO BUILD THE 'TRUST LAYER' FOR IT. A SHIFT TO CONTINUOUS AI ASSURANCE** WILL BE KEY



Every technology cycle throws up a moment when trust and infrastructure must be built at the same time. As AI embeds itself into banking, healthcare, government and defence, security can no longer be treated as just conventional cybersecurity. Organisations must protect not only traditional networks, applications and endpoints, but also foundation models, proprietary data, specialised AI applications and, increasingly, autonomous agents that can interpret instructions, access systems and execute real-world actions.

This is India's opening, but only if we treat trusted AI as an industry to be built. The urgency is evident. The 2026 Cyber Security Outlook of DSCI (Data Security Council of India) finds AI-powered cyberattacks to be the top concern for 80 per cent of CISOs (chief information security officers), up 19 percentage points year-on-year, while 62 per cent identify AI-driven social engineering as a critical threat. Around 80 per cent of organisations have encountered risky behaviour from AI agents, including improper data exposure and unauthorised system access. The security perimeter itself is changing. Non-human identities, including machine and AI agents, now outnumber human identities by 144 to one, growing 56 per cent in a year. One in 20 machine identities carries full administrative privileges.

India is not a bystander to this. A Boston Consulting Group (BCG) study on banking, financial services and insurance (BFSI) cybersecurity found that Indian institutions face cyberattacks at 1.6 times the global intensity. Cyber incidents rose from 1.4 million in 2021 to 2.9 million in 2025.

Why this is India's opening

Three things are converging. First is scale. India generates nearly 20 per cent of the world's data but hosts only around 3 per cent of global data centre capacity. That gap is beginning to close. A report by BCG and Microsoft says India's first 1.5 GW of data centre capacity took nearly two

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